

SAURABH SINGH



Irresistible KARACHI

The personal and the political merge effortlessly in this Pakistani novel

By Gillian Wright

This is Azhar Abidi's second novel. His first, *Passarola Rising*, was the adventure of a 17th century flying ship. *Twilight* could not be more different and is much closer to his personal experience. Abidi lives in Australia but was educated in Pakistan. *Twilight* is set in Pakistan and Australia. The fact that it is

published here is one of the many examples of the peoples of India and Pakistan communicating peacefully with one another through literature and the arts. Despite all the serious difficulties and the tensions there have been and remain between the two nations, these are positive signs.

Abidi's story revolves around a widowed mother and her son. She is a *mohajir* from a prosperous and distinguished family. Her son studies abroad, and, much to his mother's disappointment and his own surprise, falls in love with and marries an Australian girl. The inner struggle of an elderly mother torn between her own country and the need to be with her children as she grows

frail is one that resonates around the world. The accommodation needed if parents with traditional views are to accept their offspring's cross-cultural marriages is another area of common experience, especially in India and Pakistan.

Although these themes are of universal appeal, Bilqis Begum, Abidi's central character, lives in a particular place—Karachi—and at a particular period, as General Zia began the widespread Islamisation of the country for political ends. Abidi describes how young non-Kashmiri men were openly recruited and trained to fight against Indian forces in Kashmir, and how they were indoctrinated to consider themselves "freedom fighters". One of his characters is a man who chose this path but Abidi does not look at the Kashmir issue in depth, or consider the Indian point of view any more than the "freedom fighter" he has invented does. The growing lawlessness of Karachi and the increasing conflict between *mohajirs* and Pathans is another of the themes against which the plot of the novel is played out. Although neither Bilqis Begum nor her son have any interest in politics, there are occasions they cannot avoid it. Bilqis Begum is dumbfounded when she is confronted by violent student demonstrations in the university where she teaches.

But the main action of *Twilight* takes place within the increasingly dilapidated walls of the house of Bilqis Begum. This house almost becomes a character in its own right, a constant peeling presence. It houses her books and her memories and claims her loyalty. All those who enter its doors—Bilqis Begum's son, her daughter-in-law, relatives and servants are all very carefully conceived, the nuances of their relationships very sharply observed. Abidi writes with the refinement and elegance that is the hallmark of Bilqis Begum herself. The themes of the novel may be familiar, but Abidi's treatment is fresh and totally realistic. The women characters in particular are well drawn and unpredictably strong. The result is a novel as compelling as the best family drama, once picked up very difficult indeed to put down.



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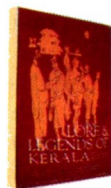
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